INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #17 · RELATIVES

"I have to keep everyone in my family happy."

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Where it often comes from

Some of us became the family peacekeeper early, learning to read moods and smooth things over before anyone exploded. We may have been rewarded for it or been afraid not to. As adults, we can feel responsible for everyone's feelings at holidays, in group chats, and in every decision, and exhausted by the effort.

What Scripture teaches

Proverbs says, "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high." Paul says, "If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone," which acknowledges that sometimes it is not possible. He also writes of seeking to please God and not people: "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God?" and "each one should carry his own load." Jesus Himself "frequently withdrew to the wilderness to pray," though people were still in need. Peacemaking is a calling. Keeping everyone happy is not.

> *"The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high"* (Proverbs 29:25).

Also see

> "If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone" (Romans 12:18).

> "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ" (Galatians 1:10).

> "Yet He frequently withdrew to the wilderness to pray" (Luke 5:16).

> "For each one should carry his own load" (Galatians 6:5).

Common self-statements

- If someone is upset, I must have done something.
- I cannot say no without causing a blowup.
- I have to make sure everyone has a good time.
- It is my job to keep the peace.
- I cannot relax until everyone is okay.
- Their moods are my responsibility.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Treating other people's feelings as my responsibility.
- Mind reading: Trying to predict and manage everyone's reactions.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should keep everyone satisfied.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining that one unhappy person will ruin everything.

Challenging questions

- When did I first become the one who kept everyone happy?
- What do I fear will happen if someone is upset with me?

- What are others responsible for in managing their own feelings?
- What is the difference between peacemaking and people-pleasing?
- What would I do differently if I trusted God with the outcome?
- What is one small thing I can let others handle?

Truth summary

> I can be kind and a peacemaker without being responsible for everyone's happiness. Each person carries their own load, and God is the one I ultimately answer to. I can set small limits and trust God with how others respond.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Fear
- Pride
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love, For Others
- Peace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Communication
- Anxiety/Worry/Fear

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I have to keep everyone in my family happy"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to keep everyone in my family happy." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When did I become the peacekeeper?
- ☐ What do I fear?
- ☐ What are others responsible for?
- ☐ What is one thing I can release?
- ☐ How can I say no kindly?
- ☐ When can I be alone with God?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The fear of man is a snare.
- ☐ I can live at peace as far as it depends on me.
- ☐ Each person carries their own load.
- ☐ Peacemaking is not people-pleasing.
- ☐ Jesus withdrew to pray.
- ☐ I can trust God with others' reactions.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Proverbs 29:25
  "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high."
- ☐ Romans 12:18
  "If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone."
- ☐ Galatians 6:5
  "For each one should carry his own load."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Let it be theirs: Each week, write one task or feeling you let someone else carry.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 29:25 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Trusting the Lord sets me securely on high, even when someone is unhappy.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Fear" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] List your duties. Write what you try to manage for others at gatherings.
- [ ] Release one. Choose one thing to hand to someone else this week.
- [ ] Practice a calm no. Rehearse a kind, short way to decline.
- [ ] Take time alone. Withdraw to pray, like Jesus did.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to keep everyone in my family happy": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A load released
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to keep everyone in my family happy.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I have tried to keep everyone happy and I am worn out. Teach me to be a peacemaker without carrying what is not mine. Help me trust You with how others feel. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.